



Historic feat:

Manpreet Singh was the captain of the Indian team that broke a 41-year-old Olympic medal drought in Tokyo by bagging the bronze.

K MURALI KUMAR

team is preparing for the Asia Cup, a qualifier for the 2026 World Cup.

Manpreet captained India to bronze at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021, ending a 41-year Games medal drought. Now, he wants to help end the nation's 51-year wait for a world title. "*Sabko World Cup jeetna hain* (Every athlete wants to win the World Cup). Every team wants to do well in big tournaments. It has been ages since we last won a World Cup medal, and it is high time we change it."

When he broke into the national setup as an 18-year-old alongside Sardar Singh, the team entered an era where fitness was valued as much as skill. Now the senior-most figure in the side, he is again leading by example, arriving at camp leaner than ever, which he says makes him "faster than before." "Several talented youngsters are coming through the ranks; they are fit. So, if

I have to compete with them, if I want to play good hockey for the next two to four years, then I have to be fitter than ever," says Manpreet.

As a Cristiano Ronaldo diehard, he has borrowed more than the Portuguese superstar's number 7 shirt. "I'm a huge fan of his mindset. Despite being over 40, he maintains his body like a youngster. I always draw inspiration from his work ethic. Even at this age, he has the hunger and continues to play well."

His renewed fitness focus paid off. In a bleak FIH Pro League 2024-25 campaign, he emerged as one of the few bright spots. After starting strongly in Bhubaneswar with 15 points, the team slumped in Europe, adding only three more and finishing eighth out of nine. A record seven-match losing streak was broken only by Ireland's poorer run, sparing India from relegation.

Despite the results, Manpreet



India best performances at World Cups

- Third place in 1971 (Inaugural edition)
- Runner-up in 1973 (Second edition)
- Champion in 1975 (Third edition)

sees value in the experience. "We live in a result-oriented world, and it didn't go our way. However, it made us identify our mistakes. We didn't play bad hockey, but there were some silly mistakes and lapses in concentration in our game. Ahead of the Asia Cup and leading to the World Cup, we will have to become better in every aspect," says the 2019 FIH Player of the Year.

During this period, on June 15, 2025, Manpreet became only the